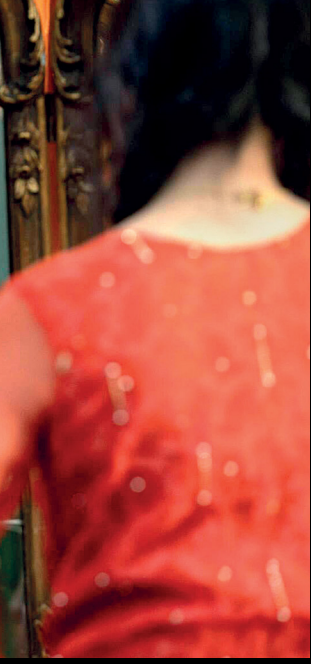




BANGLE MAGIC
Iman Vellani as Kamala Khan in various scenes from Marvel Studios' *Ms Marvel*

tion's trauma. On the surface, there is much in *Ms Marvel* that South Asians can enjoy together—the soundtrack, especially, features everyone from A.R. Rahman, M.I.A. and Eva B—but by acknowledging the violence that has shaped the subcontinent, it escapes the usual clichés of diaspora dramedies. Kamala Khan clearly has what it takes to beat evil, but if taken seriously, she could even mitigate hate.

In an interview she gave recently, actor Iman Vellani said, "I don't think we can represent all two billion Muslims and South Asians, but it's a start. And I think it's great that we're showing, you know, Muslims on screen having fun." Kamala flirts with Kamran (Rish Shah) by asking him to name his favourite Shah Rukh Khan film. ("*Baazigar*," he says, perhaps controversially.) For the show's Muslim community, Eid is a carnival, a festival they celebrate in the streets of Jersey City. Kamala is not unduly rebuked when she hollers to her masjid's imam from the women's enclosure to say, "It is just really hard to concentrate when we can barely see you." More than the effects, little touches like these feel special.

It was in 2014 that the character of *Ms Marvel* was given her own comic book series. The concerns of tokenism that existed then have only been amplified today. Is 'diversity' a slogan that distracts from Marvel's possible real interest—a new demographic? Purchased in 2009 for just $4 billion, Marvel Entertainment is now said to be worth $53 billion, approximately 16 per cent of its parent company Disney's market value.

The posters and paraphernalia in Kamala's room are all reminders of how Marvel has made us put our money where Disney's mouth is. That said, *Ms Marvel* has given us South Asians something no MCU (Marvel Cinematic Universe) offering has offered before—a superhero wholly ours. ■

- Shreevatsa Nevatia

ASIAN FLAVOURS

Flag-bearers of the continent in the MCU



KINGO
Kingo (Kumail Nanjiani) is not of this planet, but his Bollywood dance moves, his delight, the way he says *dishoom* when killing a foe in the forest, all add sparkle to Marvel's tepid *Eternals*.

SHANG-CHI
In *Shang-Chi and The Legend of the Ten Rings*, we meet a Chinese protagonist who transforms from martial arts master to assassin, then to a valet driver, and, finally, to a superhero.





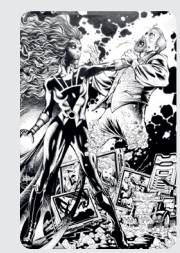
WONG
Wong is many things—Sorcerer Supreme, protector of the New York Sanctum and librarian of Kamar-Taj—but you might only remember the Nepalese hero as Doctor Strange's sidekick.

For the Books

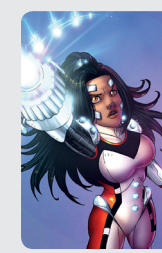
The South Asians breaking bones and stereotypes in comics



ARUNA
DC's Aruna is a shapeshifting, genderfluid, no-nonsense crime fighter. Born in Chennai, Aruna found a home in Bollywood as a stunt double. Last we read, the superhero was assisting Batgirl.



CELSIUS
Created by DC in 1977, Celsius commands fire, ice and her own team of superheroes, Doom Patrol. Before she turned caped crusader, family and friends knew her only as Arani Desai.



OMEGA SENTINEL
Had fate and villainy not transformed Karima Shapandar, a Kolkata police officer, into a sentinel, this superhero would have lived happily with her now-mutant boyfriend Neal.